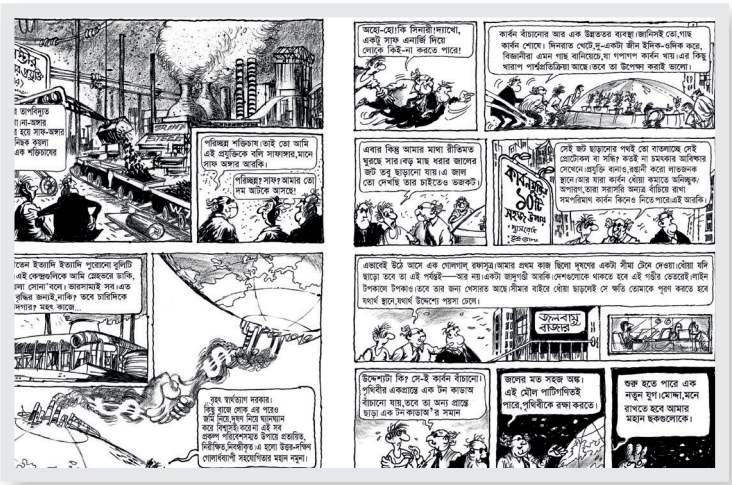
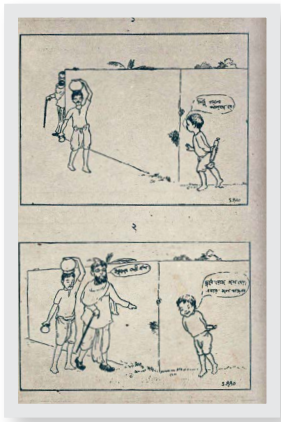
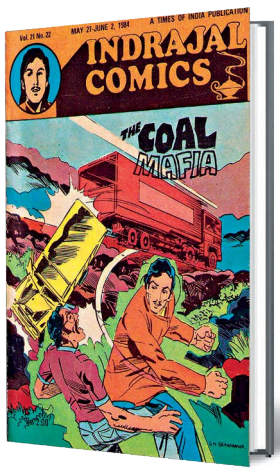




**COMIC EDUCATION**
Clockwise from top: *Carbon Kotha*, '*Jamon kormo temni fol*' by Sukhalata Rao, Indrajal Comics's *Bahadur*, Narayan Debnath and his cast of creations, *Longform 2022*




**Part of the Collective's stash are Bengali translations of Hindi comics from the '70s and '80s, like Aabid Surti's *Bahadur***

efforts but, really, the credit goes to each member of the Collective who has devoted their time to this endeavour. And we have been overwhelmed with the response—the Kolkata Centre for Creativity saw record footfalls during our exhibition."

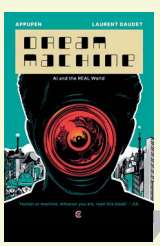
According to De, there is an absence of reliable metadata around these comics, a situation the Comics Culture Collective is trying to amend. "When the metadata is incomplete or contradictory, it leads to errors by academics, which then become part of the record, which leads to further errors in the future," he says.

The exhibits at *Comics in Bengal* covered the entire gamut of sequential art, including works from the 1920s onwards up until contemporary comics. In fact, some of the exhibits date back to the 1870s and can be considered precursors of modern-day comics—these are *patachitras*, terracotta panels and other examples of pre-modern sequential art. Sukhalata Rao (1886-1969), elder sister to Sukumar Ray and aunt to Satyajit, is considered one of the pioneers of Bengali comics. Panels from her strip '*Jemon Kormo Temni Fol* (As you sow, so shall you reap)' were a part of the exhibit.

Talking about these early days of Bengali comics, De says, "The political expression in these comics became more overt from the 1930s onwards; before that, in the '20s, there were mostly juvenile stories or things with a clearly-defined 'moral'."

An important part of the Collective's stash are Bengali translations of Hindi comics from the 1970s and '80s, like Aabid Surti's *Bahadur*, a popular vigilante series published by Indrajal Comics. Among contemporary works, Sarbajit Sen's '*Carbon Kotha* (Carbon Chronicles)', a nonfiction Bangla comic on climate change, has contemporary relevance. "We have planned a big, full-scale book collecting all these strips later this year," says De. "We are currently in talks with some international publishers as well. Hopefully, soon we will be able to deliver an English-language version so that we can take Bengali comics to the world." ■

**–Aditya Mani Jha**




**DREAM MACHINE**
**AI and the Real World**
*by Appupen and Laurent Daudet*
CONTEXT/ WESTLAND
**₹599;**
**160** pages

The creators of this comic–Appupen, who sprang on to the Indian comics scene in 2009 with *Moonward*, and Laurent Daudet, a Paris-based physics professor and co-founder of an AI start-up–address the most burning question of our times: Is AI a force for good, or does it threaten the future of humanity? The story centres around Hugo, founder of an AI start-up, who is about to sell his technology to a large digital conglomerate. But its true motives are suspect and Hugo is caught in a dilemma. It's somewhat didactic and the dialogue can be stilted at times, but that's a small price for a serious exploration of AI and its ramifications.




**THE PIG FLIP**
*by Joshy Benedict*
HARPERCOLLINS
**₹499;**
**120**
pages

Joshy Benedict's debut graphic novel–*The Pig Flip*–was acclaimed when it came out in Malayalam as *Pannimalath*. It's a graphic novel in the classic mould, taking sheer joy in the storytelling even as it grapples with its grim subject matter. The story revolves around spot flip, a card game a group of men meet on an abandoned island in rural Kerala at midnight to play. They gamble too and the protagonist Babycha becomes hopelessly addicted. He tries to wean himself off, but succumbs again. A moving tale of addiction and its social repercussions.

**–Amit Dixit**